PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz Unimog 404

1955–1980 · 404.1 · Unimog S · M180 petrol I6

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Drain the gear oils before you pay**
  Expedition Portal owners say to pull the plugs on the hubs, diffs and gearbox and look for tar or metal bits, and to check the tires for oil flung from leaking portal seals. Seals between the axle and the portal hub can blow and, if you keep driving, take the gears with them.

- [ ] **Check the front diff for too much oil**
  Rocky Mountain Moggers point out that a leaking transmission output seal doesn't show outside: the oil runs down inside the drive-shaft tube and overfills the differential. A front diff that drains more oil than it should points to the gearbox seal.

- [ ] **Look at the brakes, wheel by wheel**
  Bring a Trailer listings regularly mention a leaking wheel cylinder or a recent brake overhaul. Look for fluid on the backing plates and inside the rims, and check the pedal. Rebuilt cylinders and new hoses are a good sign, not a red flag.

- [ ] **Listen to the clutch and throw-out bearing**
  A squeaking throw-out bearing is a warning; caught early it can sometimes be greased in place, and if not it's a big job. Expedition Imports also traced a run of pressure-plate failures to puck-style clutch discs installed the way the old manual shows. One veteran suggests a written promise of a refund if the engine, gearbox, clutch or throw-out bearing turns out bad.

- [ ] **Be suspicious of 'ran when parked'**
  A Steel Soldiers member was offered two parked 404s at $8,500 each and found stale fuel, old tires, leaking pinion seals and portal hubs, a rotted bed and a torn top. Expedition Imports has photographed cylinder-head damage in an engine that sat unused for eight years. Long storage usually means fuel, brakes, seals and canvas.

- [ ] **Find out where it served**
  Most US trucks are ex-military. One Steel Soldiers member warns against French trucks as abused and poorly maintained, and says Swiss trucks are usually well kept (you can tell them by the taller cab cover). Belgian and Swiss service histories show up often in auction listings.

- [ ] **Inspect the cylinder head and fuel tanks**
  Expedition Imports says the most common M 180 head failure is a water jacket that rots out close to the head-gasket seal, so look for coolant in the oil. Rust or orange flakes in the fuel filters mean the tank lining is peeling.

- [ ] **Know what voltage you're buying**
  Military 404s run 24 volts with shielded, radio-suppressed ignition. That's fine once you know it, but it changes the bulbs, starter, battery and any accessories you add. Check that it charges, and ask whether the ignition has already been converted.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Chassis number = type number**
  The first six digits are the Baumuster (type number), followed by the serial: for example 404114050657 or 404115031210 in Bring a Trailer listings. 404.111 is the early short-wheelbase truck, 404.112–115 the main 404.1 series, 404.117 the Portuguese diesel, and 404.010–013 the 404.0.

- [ ] **404.1 vs 404.0**
  The 404.1 has the original cab with a split windshield. The 404.0 uses the Unimog 406 cab (or the 416's folding-top cab) with a one-piece windshield. German Wikipedia says you can still tell a 404.0 from a 406-based Unimog by its external wheel hubs, which the 406 family doesn't have.

- [ ] **Engine numbers**
  The Unimog 404 Guide lists M 180 engine numbers 180.928, 180.953 and 180.958 for the 404.0 and 404.1, and 130.925 for the M 130 in the 404.0. Anything else, such as an OM617 diesel or a car-sourced engine, is a swap.

- [ ] **Old- or new-style cylinder head**
  Old-style M 180 heads have a more complex valve train with extra rocker shafts and a hollow, drilled camshaft, which fails more often. New-style heads have a solid cam with a drip-oiler tube. An old-style valve cover only fits an old-style head, but a new-style cover fits both.

- [ ] **Military equipment**
  Ex-army trucks have 24-volt electrics, a shielded, radio-suppressed ignition and military light switches, and sometimes blackout lights and air-over-hydraulic brakes. A Steel Soldiers member says Swiss trucks can be spotted by their taller cab cover.

NOTES

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